

OSINT 101

OSINT Operations Checklist

End-to-end operational checklist for structured OSINT investigations

Open-Source Intelligence, Explained

osint101.com

Phase I: Pre-Operation Planning

Scope & Objective

- ☐ Investigation objective clearly defined
- ☐ Scope boundaries established (in/out of scope)
- ☐ Target persona / entity identified
- ☐ Research questions formulated
- ☐ Success criteria defined

Legal & Ethics

- ☐ Jurisdictional legal review completed
- ☐ Data protection regulations (GDPR/CCPA) assessed
- ☐ Terms of service constraints documented
- ☐ Ethics approval obtained (if required)
- ☐ Engagement rules defined
- ☐ Stop conditions documented

Operational Setup

- ☐ Workspace isolation verified (VM/sandbox)
- ☐ VPN/proxy infrastructure tested
- ☐ Clean browser profiles created
- ☐ Burner accounts / sock puppets ready
- ☐ Secure communication channels established
- ☐ Data storage encrypted and access-controlled

Tools & Resources

- ☐ Toolchain verified and tested
- ☐ Source list prepared
- ☐ Search queries / dork templates prepared
- ☐ Backup tools identified
- ☐ Reference materials on hand

Phase II: Active Collection

Collection

- ☐ Systematic collection initiated (ordered by priority)
- ☐ Search queries executed and logged
- ☐ Results captured with timestamps
- ☐ Screenshots taken with metadata preserved
- ☐ HTML/PDF snapshots saved
- ☐ API queries rate-limited appropriately

Verification

- ☐ Cross-reference findings with multiple sources
- ☐ Admiralty reliability ratings assigned
- ☐ Timestamps and context verified
- ☐ Geolocation metadata validated
- ☐ Biases identified and documented

Documentation

- ☐ Chain of custody maintained
- ☐ Evidence artifacts hashed (SHA-256)
- ☐ Observations recorded in investigation log
- ☐ Source index updated
- ☐ Confidence levels assigned to each finding

Phase III: Post-Operation

Analysis & Reporting

- [] Raw data analysed and cross-referenced
- [] Key findings extracted and prioritised
- [] Report drafted per OSINT Report Template
- [] Confidence assessments reviewed
- [] Alternative hypotheses documented
- [] Peer review completed

Archival

- [] Case file compiled with all evidence
- [] Evidence artefacts archived with manifests
- [] Chain of custody documentation finalised
- [] Data retention schedule defined
- [] Backup created to secure storage

Cleanup & Debrief

- [] Workspace wiped / sanitised
- [] Burner accounts deactivated
- [] VPN/proxy logs cleared
- [] Lessons learned documented
- [] Client / stakeholder debrief completed
- [] Post-investigation review scheduled

Quick Reference: Investigation Lifecycle

